

follow dreams and given each other the independence to do so.

Tessolve was Raja's first venture as an entrepreneur, the one he funded by taking a loan against his house in the States. This was also the first time that Raja was embarking on a journey to start a venture in India, as he wanted to start giving back to the country which had helped him become what he was today. "I met a couple of brilliant guys while starting Tessolve. I must say that I have been lucky my entire life. You always need a little bit of luck, and these brilliant guys I met were my share of that good luck. This pinch of good luck enables you to cross the line," says Raja.

Not only the hard work of Raja (he prefers to call it luck) started paying off in terms of the people he was able to hire, but Qualcomm also decided to invest in Tessolve, and it was Qualcomm's first venture investment in the country. Similarly, Applied Materials also invested in Tessolve, followed by Jafco.

However, things were always not a cakewalk for Tessolve. The startup lost most of its projects after the crash of 2008 and was on the verge of bankruptcy. "I was sure that survival was not possible but what kept me going was the faith that what I was doing would reap good results for India and for the semiconductor industry. I had faith in the expertise and delivery that we were developing," notes Raja.

Then followed the beg, borrow, and steal approach. Raja would knock every door he knew asking for a loan. Raja shares, there were three times he thought that Tessolve would go bankrupt. And once the president of the company walked up to him and told him that they should tell employees that Tessolve would not be able to pay salaries!

Raja in such cases would usually ask for a day or two and borrow all the money he could and try to pay salaries. "It was fortunate that we survived every time. If you believe in something, then you must be ready to do everything to make sure that something survives. I did not draw a salary from Tessolve for almost two-and-a-half years, but I never missed a payroll. That is what has helped us build integrity at Tessolve," Raja shares.

Some less known facts about Raja Manickam

One advice I would give to my younger self - Mitigate your risks more

Go to person - My Wife

Favourite book - PG Wodehouse

Favourite recipe - Chettinad Chicken

Cars or bikes - Cars

Car I drive today - Toyota Camry

Dream car - Mercedes

Favourite leader - Previous manager Mr Sassan

Favourite actor - MGR

Favourite actress - Bharti

Favourite movie - Enga Veettu Pillai (Tamil)

He recalled an incident where one of the leading banks of the country had loaned around eighty million rupees to Tessolve, and the startup was finding it difficult to pay the installments. This was during the crash that happened around 2013-14. Raja would walk up to the bank and try to explain what was going on and why the company was missing installments. "I had a rule that whatever was going on and hurting the business, I will go to the banks, the vendors and everyone else included in Tessolve to explain the complete situation," explains Raja.

"I will give credit to this national bank that they understood my problem. The officer who was incharge of the Tessolve account was also incharge of the Kingfisher deal, and he would tell me sir here you are explaining what's delaying the payments, and then there is this Kingfisher guy who only God knows is where. He owes us thousand crores and he is not showing up," Raja shares jokingly.

He adds, "But he was also bound by the rules of the bank, which required him to put up a notice at our office about the payments. This got me worried as my employees reading that message would create a negative environment. The bank officer himself suggested to put the notice at night, so we could remove it overnight and not alarm the employees about the company's problem to pay bank dues.

Tessolve made it a point that in case the startup had to delay payments to its vendors, it will never delay the payment of small vendors but request big companies to give the startup more time. This was done keeping in mind

how small vendors were dependent on Tessolve more than anybody else. The most important thing, as Raja points out, is if he would have succeeded the way he had planned, it probably would have made him arrogant. But the way he got successful, by going through those ups and downs, is what taught him to stay humble no matter what.

"The idea with Tessolve was not to fill up spreadsheets of any kind to make it look attractive to investors and clients. The idea with Tessolve was all about making it the topmost semiconductor services company," he adds, and that is why Raja's contribution to the company stayed with it for a long time, even after it was acquired by the Hero Group. Raja's daughter is still working with the company as one of the top business development professionals at Tessolve. Tessolve today has offices located in different parts of the world.

"If you build anything, build it to last," he explains. Tessolve originally was meant to be the first manufacturing ATMP in India, but as Raja learnt that no one was interested in funding such a venture in the country, he had to change course and focus on semiconductor services. This is probably why Raja is with Tata now, working on establishing an ATMP/OSAT in the country. Raja still remembers a professor who had once told him, "Raja you are not made for writing codes or doing software. You are made for doing something revolutionary in the field of electronics manufacturing."

The man behind India's semiconductor dream says, "Those words still echo in my mind." **EFY**